The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

16th January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Inundate (प्रवाहित करना)

Meaning: To overwhelm with a large amount of something, especially water.
Synonyms: Flood, overwhelm, submerge
Antonyms: Drain, dehydrate, dry
Example: The sudden rainfall caused the river to inundate the nearby villages.

2. Scrupulous (सतर्क, निष्ठावान)

Meaning: Very careful and thorough in doing something, especially regarding moral integrity.
Synonyms: Conscientious, meticulous, ethical
Antonyms: Careless, negligent, unethical
Example: She is a scrupulous researcher, ensuring every detail is accurate.

VOCABULARY

3. Connivance (साजिश, मिलीभगत)

Meaning: Willingness to secretly allow or be involved in wrongdoing.
Synonyms: Collusion, complicity, conspiracy
Antonyms: Opposition, resistance, disapproval
Example: The company's success was built on the connivance of corrupt officials.

4. Byzantine (जटिल, उलझा हुआ)

Meaning: Very complex or intricate, especially in structure or administration.
Synonyms: Complex, convoluted, labyrinthine
Antonyms: Simple, straightforward, clear
Example: The company's byzantine policies made it difficult for employees to understand the procedures.

VOCABULARY

5. Conundrum (पहेली, उलझन)

Meaning: A confusing or difficult problem or question.
Synonyms: Puzzle, dilemma, problem
Antonyms: Solution, answer, resolution
Example: The decision to invest in the new project posed a real conundrum for the board members.

6. Felicitated (सम्मानित किया)

Meaning: To praise or honor someone, especially publicly.
Synonyms: Congratulated, honored, acknowledged
Antonyms: Criticized, reprimanded, denounced
Example: The employees were felicitated for their exceptional performance in the annual awards ceremony.

VOCABULARY

7. Inevitable (अपरिहार्य)

Meaning: Certain to happen; unavoidable.
Synonyms: Unavoidable, certain, inescapable
Antonyms: Avoidable, uncertain, preventable
Example: The failure of the project was inevitable due to poor planning and lack of resources.

8. Banal (साधारण , नीरस)

Meaning: Lacking originality or freshness; dull.
Synonyms: Trite, cliche, dull
Antonyms: Original, unique, fresh
Example: The movie's plot was so banal that it failed to engage the audience.

VOCABULARY

9. Scrutiny (परीक्षण, जांच)

Meaning: Careful and thorough examination or inspection.
Synonyms: Inspection, examination, analysis
Antonyms: Glance, neglect, disregard
Example: The proposal underwent intense scrutiny before being approved by the committee.

10. Unleash (रिहा करना, खोलना)

Meaning: To release or set something free, often something powerful or destructive.
Synonyms: Release, discharge, let loose
Antonyms: Contain, restrain, hold back
Example: The decision to cut costs may unleash a wave of employee layoffs.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Hand in
Meaning: to give something to someone in a position of authority

2. Cut in
Meaning: interrupt someone while they are speaking

3. Break out
Meaning: to begin, or to begin using or doing something / a violent escape, especially by a group

4. Turn up
Meaning: to arrive; to appear

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Be in the swim

Meaning: To keep oneself informed and up-to-date

2. Can’t cut the mustard

Meaning: Someone who is not adequate enough to compete or participate

3. Variety is the spice of life

Meaning: New and exciting experiences make life more interesting

VOCABULARY

4. Wag the dog

Meaning: To change the topic from something that is more important to something that is not

5. Thumb one's nose

Meaning: A gesture of disrespect

Article for Reading

Burrow tragedy: on the coal mining tragedy in Assam’s Dima Hasao

With four deaths so far, the coal mining tragedy in Assam's Dima Hasao district has revived a long-standing debate on the hazardous nature of rat-hole coal mining in India. As opposed to modern coal mining, which is mechanised, the 'rat-hole' points to the crude and antiquated technique of employing people, and even children, to burrow into the ground to scoop out the underground coal. Depending on the depths that they plumb, the odds are high that their pickaxes will often unleash a torrent of water from a hidden aquifer that can suddenly inundate the excavated tunnel — as it is suspected to have happened at Dima Hasao. Because such accidents have recurred over the decades, along with the attendant health and environmental hazards, this mode of mining was banned by the National Green Tribunal (NGT) in 2014. The use of proper geological surveys and appropriate machinery would have made the mine economically unviable.

The Assam Chief Minister has stated that the mine appeared to be “prime facie... illegal” and one abandoned by the State’s Mines and Minerals Department. If that is the case, it reflects poorly on the State administration that such mines can be exploited by unscrupulous elements with such ease, despite the ban. Surely, this is only a fraction of the unregulated mining that actually goes on. The Supreme Court of India, in 2019, had asked whether it was possible for such mining to continue without the “connivance” of officials, when it was examining the rescue of 15 miners trapped in a rat-hole mine in the East Jaintia Hills in December 2018. A report submitted by a monitoring committee set up by the NGT observed that despite the ban, the demand for coal to power cement manufacturing and thermal power plants in the northeast had sustained and supported rat-hole coal mining.

On the other hand, when convenient, State authorities have sought out and even felicitated rat-hole miners, some from Assam, as in 2023, when they were called in as a last resort after advanced machinery and the expertise of professional geologists and earth scientists had failed to rescue 41 construction workers trapped in the large, over-ground Silkiyara tunnel in Uttarkashi. The Dima Hasao operation too, like others, will end and the net success or failure of saving those trapped will induce a familiar amnesia that will be broken only by the next accident. Until decisive action to puncture the economics of rat-hole mining is taken, India is only burrowing the way to another tragedy.

Summary

The passage discusses a recent tragedy in Assam's Dima Hasao district, where a coal mining accident resulted in four deaths. The tragedy highlights the dangerous practice of rat-hole coal mining, a crude, manual method involving people, sometimes even children, digging underground to extract coal. This method, unlike mechanized mining, poses serious health and environmental risks, as well as frequent accidents. Despite being banned by the National Green Tribunal (NGT) in 2014, rat-hole mining persists due to the continued demand for coal in the northeast, contributing to economic pressures. The passage criticizes the lack of effective enforcement of the ban, with some state officials seemingly turning a blind eye or even facilitating such mining. It emphasizes that the cycle of accidents and amnesia will continue unless decisive actions are taken to address the root causes of rat-hole mining.

The tone of the passage is critical and concerned, with a strong sense of frustration directed at the lack of regulation and enforcement regarding rat-hole coal mining. The author highlights the grave consequences of such practices and the failure of authorities to address them effectively, suggesting a deep sense of disillusionment with the government's inaction.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
How did the Supreme Court of India respond to the continued practice of rat-hole mining in 2019?

a) The Supreme Court upheld the legality of rat-hole mining in the northeast.
b) The Supreme Court ordered the immediate cessation of all rat-hole mining activities.
c) The Supreme Court questioned whether such mining could continue without the involvement of officials.
d) The Supreme Court authorized rat-hole mining under specific conditions for emergency purposes.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What has been a recurring issue in the aftermath of rat-hole mining accidents like Dima Hasao?

a) State authorities have continually improved mining safety regulations.
b) After accidents, the State has offered support to the families of those affected.
c) The government has started funding more advanced mining techniques.
d) The net success or failure of saving trapped miners often leads to amnesia until the next accident.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What is the primary reason for the lack of enforcement against illegal rat-hole mining, as suggested in the passage?

a) The government lacks resources to monitor all mining activities.
b) Officials have been complicit in allowing illegal mining to continue.
c) The demand for coal outweighs the risks associated with rat-hole mining.
d) The ban on rat-hole mining is ineffective because of insufficient public awareness.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

How Much Supervision Should Companies Give AI Agents?

We are witnessing a revolutionary shift from basic AI chatbots to true cognitive agents — systems that can think strategically, plan, and learn from their successes and failures. However, if we always put humans in the loop, we are unlikely to attain the true benefits of AI transformation. So, how much freedom should we grant AI agents? Surprisingly, the answer is about more than how big the risks are; it's about how well we understand those risks. Too little latitude, and the agent's capabilities are constrained to answering basic questions. Too much autonomy, and brand, reputation, customer relationships, and even financial stability are at risk. One approach is to wait until a general regulatory and commercial consensus on agentic AI emerges. Alternatively, for those bold enough, uncertainty can be harnessed as a decision rule for knowing what to do next. AI agents are systems for taking action. Unlike chatbots, they use large language models to orchestrate complex problem-solving activities involving planning, reasoning, and even interactions with other AI agents.

Think of them as highly efficient virtual co-workers or a form of digital labor. Billions of them will soon join the workforce and will materially change the output of companies. The purpose of an AI agent is to get something done — such as an employee requesting a leave of absence, a sales assistant engaging a valued retail client with personalized recommendations, or a pharmaceutical executive prioritizing the best candidates to recruit for a clinical trial. AI agents can become a control layer around all kinds of transactions, replacing many of the complex interfaces and byzantine workflows that characterize enterprise software platforms. Their simplicity and usefulness will be a direct challenge to both traditional software-as-a-service vendors, as well as to technology leaders unprepared for their rapid proliferation. Despite the anxiety around the arrival of artificial general intelligence (AGI), there may be more to fear from these relatively banal systems that will soon make millions of micro-decisions that impact our daily lives and work. Agent autonomy is a conundrum.

You lose your productivity gains if you impose excessive supervision. Yet, in many cases, supervision is precisely what is needed to avoid disaster. Since the emergence of generative AI, there have been sufficient examples of algorithmic anarchy to make leaders wary — from an auto dealer chatbot offering a brand new car for a dollar, to an airline that was held liable for policies its AI chatbot hallucinated that did not exist. To avoid that problem, organizations are building AI agents that connect directly to internal systems and data, and new standards are emerging. That is a double-edged sword. Agents may be less likely to make things up if they're relying on internal systems and data. But, as they become more trusted, they will also have a growing influence over life-altering actions such as approving home loans, allocating social security, protecting critical infrastructure from cyberattacks, hiring or firing staff, or even controlling lethal weapons systems.

Question 4:
What is the conundrum related to AI agent autonomy discussed in the passage?

a) AI agents will eventually operate without any human oversight.
b) Excessive supervision can undermine the productivity benefits of AI agents, while too little supervision could lead to disasters.
c) AI agents will never achieve true autonomy due to constant oversight.
d) There is no need to supervise AI agents as they will always operate within safe parameters.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
What is one of the primary risks when AI agents are integrated into critical systems like approving home loans or controlling cyber infrastructure?

a) AI agents will replace human workers in critical sectors.
b) AI agents may become overly reliant on human supervision.
c) AI agents will make incorrect decisions if they are not properly trained.
d) AI agents could influence life-altering actions, making their decisions more impactful.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Precis writing:

Original Text: Education is a fundamental pillar of personal growth and societal advancement. It empowers individuals with knowledge, critical thinking skills, and ethical values necessary for navigating life's challenges and making informed decisions. Education enhances intellectual and emotional development, fostering qualities like discipline, empathy, and resilience, which are essential for personal fulfillment and meaningful contribution to society. It also cultivates creativity and problem-solving abilities, enabling individuals to adapt and thrive in an ever-evolving world. On a broader scale, education plays a transformative role in society. It bridges socio-economic gaps, reduces inequality, and creates pathways for upward mobility. By fostering understanding and tolerance, it builds connections

among diverse groups, promoting social harmony and unity. Moreover, education equips people with the tools to address pressing global challenges such as poverty, climate change, and health crises, encouraging innovative solutions and collective responsibility. Education is not just a means to individual success but a critical driver of societal progress. It fuels economic growth by preparing skilled professionals and entrepreneurs who contribute to industries and innovation. It also strengthens democracy by empowering individuals to engage actively in civic life and advocate for equitable policies. Furthermore, education nurtures responsible leadership, ensuring that future generations can lead with integrity and purpose. As a long-term investment, education lays the foundation for sustainable progress, fostering a society where opportunities are accessible to all. It not only prepares individuals for professional success but also cultivates informed, compassionate, and active citizens capable of shaping a better and more inclusive future. In essence, education is the cornerstone of human potential and the key to building a just and prosperous world.

Precis

Education is the foundation of personal development and societal progress. It equips individuals with knowledge, critical thinking, and problem-solving skills necessary to navigate life's challenges. Beyond academic learning, education fosters emotional growth and values such as empathy, discipline, and resilience, enabling people to contribute meaningfully to their communities and adapt to a rapidly changing world. At a societal level, education plays a transformative role by reducing inequality and offering opportunities for upward mobility. It bridges gaps among diverse groups, fostering understanding, tolerance, and social harmony. Education empowers individuals to address global challenges such as poverty, climate change, and public health crises, encouraging innovative solutions and collective action. Economically, education drives growth by preparing skilled professionals and entrepreneurs who fuel industries and innovation. It strengthens democratic systems by creating informed citizens who actively engage in civic life, advocate for equitable policies, and hold leaders accountable. Furthermore, education nurtures responsible leadership, ensuring future generations are equipped to lead with integrity and purpose.

- **You are the HR of your office, ABC Ltd. Write an email informing your employees about the change in office timings for the winter season due to heavy fog.**

To: abcltd.team@gmail.com

Subject: Change in Office Timings for Winter Season

Dear Team,

I hope this message finds you well. Due to the heavy fog during the winter season, we have decided to adjust our office timings to ensure everyone's safety and convenience.

Starting from [date], the new office hours will be as follows:

Start Time: [new start time]
End Time: [new end time]
We kindly request all employees to adhere to the revised schedule. Please plan your commute accordingly and prioritize safety while traveling.

If you have any concerns or require further clarification, feel free to reach out to the HR department.

Thank you for your cooperation.

Best regards,
[Your Name]
HR Manager
ABC Ltd.

Match the column

1. Be in the swim	A. Someone who is not adequate enough to compete
2. Can’t cut the mustard	B. New experiences make life more interesting
3. Variety is the spice of life	C. A gesture of disrespect
4. Wag the dog	D. To keep oneself informed and up-to-date
5. Thumb one's nose	E. To change the topic

Answer:

1-d

2-a

3-b

4-e

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Inundate:
2. Scrupulous:
3. Connivance:
4. Byzantine:
5. Conundrum:
6. Felicitated:
7. Inevitable:
8. Banal:
9. Scrutiny:
10. Unleash:

RC ANS

1.

Ans: c

Explanation:

In 2019, the Supreme Court raised concerns about the possible involvement of officials in the illegal continuation of rat-hole mining, highlighting the issue of governmental complicity.

Reference:

“The Supreme Court of India, in 2019, had asked whether it was possible for such mining to continue without the ‘connivance’ of officials, when it was examining the rescue of 15 miners trapped in a rat-hole mine in the East Jaintia Hills in December 2018.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The Supreme Court did not uphold the legality of rat-hole mining; rather, it questioned its continued existence despite the ban.

b) The Supreme Court did not issue an immediate cessation order, but raised questions regarding official involvement.

d) The Supreme Court did not authorize rat-hole mining, nor was it mentioned as an emergency measure.

2.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage notes a cyclical pattern where the success or failure of rescuing miners from such tragedies leads to public forgetfulness, only to be revived by the next mining accident.

Reference:

“The Dima Hasao operation too, like others, will end and the net success or failure of saving those trapped will induce a familiar amnesia that will be broken only by the next accident.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The passage does not mention any continuous improvement in mining safety regulations.

b) There is no mention of State support for affected families after such accidents.

c) There is no evidence that the government has funded more advanced mining techniques post-accident.

3.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage points to the possibility of official involvement or "connivance" in allowing illegal rat-hole mining to continue, suggesting that such activities cannot happen without some form of complicity.

Reference:

“The Supreme Court of India, in 2019, had asked whether it was possible for such mining to continue without the ‘connivance’ of officials...”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The passage does not mention resource limitations; it focuses more on the complicity of officials.

c) While the demand for coal sustains rat-hole mining, the core issue is the involvement of officials in permitting it.

d) The passage doesn't suggest that public awareness is the main problem, but rather illegal practices and governmental inaction.

4.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage describes a balance that must be struck between granting AI agents enough autonomy to maximize productivity and supervising them to prevent risks, particularly in sensitive areas.

Reference:

“Agent autonomy is a conundrum. You lose your productivity gains if you impose excessive supervision. Yet, in many cases, supervision is precisely what is needed to avoid disaster.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) AI agents are not expected to operate without any human oversight, but rather with a balance of autonomy and supervision.

c) The passage does not suggest that AI agents will never achieve autonomy, only that it needs to be managed carefully.

d) The passage argues that too little supervision can cause serious problems, so this option is incorrect.

5.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage notes that AI agents, due to their growing influence, will be involved in significant decisions such as home loan approvals or cybersecurity, highlighting the high stakes involved.

Reference:

“But, as they become more trusted, they will also have a growing influence over life-altering actions such as approving home loans, allocating social security, protecting critical infrastructure from cyberattacks…”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The passage discusses the increased influence of AI agents, not their complete replacement of human workers.

b) The passage does not suggest that AI agents will become overly reliant on supervision; rather, it discusses the balance of autonomy and supervision.

c) While incorrect decisions are a risk, the main concern is the growing influence AI agents will have over critical decisions.

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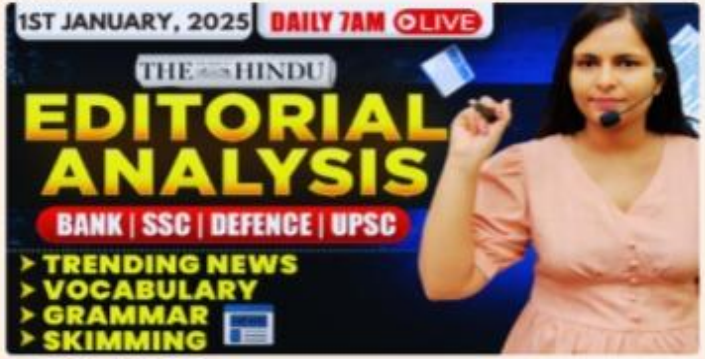

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Perfection Class: Debunking English Grammar Myths I Perfection I

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